Passages 2025

A few of the eminences that departed from our midst in the year gone by, having left an indelible mark in their respective spheres of influence



HEMANT CHAWLA

V.S. ACHUTHANANDAN | b. 1923 |

CPI(M), Ex-Kerala CM

The legendary Communist leader was a ripe old 101 when he passed away in July last year. An old-school 'Lal salaam' hardliner, he was the state's most popular leader across party lines. VS, or 'Achumama' as the young generation called him, joined the Reds when he was just 14, and was one of the founding members of the Communist Party of India (Marxist) in 1964, when it broke away from the parent Communist Party of India (CPI). VS, who always ended up second-best in the CM race, finally got the chair when he was 82 (2006-2011). His outspoken, uncompromising stand against corruption, land-grabbing and such endeared him to the public, but in later years the party cast him adrift.

K. KASTURIRANGAN | b. 1940 |

Former chairman, ISRO

Dr Kasturirangan not only led the Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO) and the Space Commission through an era of high accomplishments, but played key roles in shaping policy in India's science ecosystem in his later career as a Rajya Sabha member, Planning Commission member, and head of various academic institutions. He was the architect of the National Education Policy 2020 and led the national curriculum framework steering committee. An astrophysicist by training, it was during Kasturirangan's nine-year tenure as chairman of ISRO (1994-2003) that the space agency developed the Indian National Satellite System (INSAT-2), the Indian Remote Sensing satellites (IRS-1A and-1B), and operationalised what would become its workhorse, the Polar Satellite Launch Vehicle (PSLV).

JAYANT NARLIKAR | b. 1938 |

Astrophysicist and science educator



Jayant Vishnu Narlikar married theoretical audacity with a lifelong devotion to building India's scientific culture. Trained at Cambridge, he co-developed the Hoyle–Narlikar theory of gravity with Fred Hoyle, a heterodox alternative to the Big Bang model. His rigour as theorist as well as his anti-dogmatic streak, both showed through there—as well as in his writings. In fiction and essays, both in English and Marathi, the ever-smiling and accessible Narlikar was a gentle apostle of popular science. Awarded the Padma Bhushan at 26, he also founded the Inter-University Centre for Astronomy and Astrophysics.